site, 85 per cent of the Sundarbans' population falls in the BPL category. The rise in the maternal mortality ratio by at least 10 per cent in the coastal areas between 2005 and 2010 led Giri to start a community delivery centre in collaboration with the state's health and family welfare department under the NRHM. Over the years, it has served 922 rural women in the safe institutional delivery of newborns. It runs a 10-bed maternity clinic and holds medical camps periodically. To villagers with only around an acre of farm land, BTS has imparted professional aid so that their patches are transformed into highly productive areas yielding vegetables and lentils. "Villagers are growing paddy on slightly raised banks of their ponds, breeding fish. They get iron, vitamins and minerals from their own kitchen garden," adds Giri. BTS has also helped villagers sell their excess organic produce. The integrated farming approach has now increased farm earning three times from the meagre Rs 2,500 a month.

"I now earn Rs 40,000 a month from farm produce and Rs 12,000 a year from fish farming," says 36-year-old Soumen Samanta of Moipith-Nagenabad. "Even without ponds, BTS has taught us how to grow fish by digging drains around the field. Organic farming has taken off because of BTS—giving us seeds, other inputs and training free of cost." Rashmoni Kayal of Baikunthapur says, "Now men don't feel the need of leaving the villages. There's so much to do that no one sits idle." Rashmoni and other village women now complement their family income by doing tailoring and zaree work at a nearby Usha Silai School that is run with the BTS. Another BTS team, in collaboration with the Sneh Foundation, supplies low-cost sanitary napkins to students and housewives.

Besides all this, BTS has its own disaster mitigation task force for quick and on-the-spot response to natural calamities that are the bane of the Sundarbans, helping administration in prompt evacuation, rescue and distribution of relief. During the Amphan and Yaas cyclones, they saved many lives. Susanta Giri is a happy man today. His life's work has changed thousands of lives. ■

Nurturing the Next Generation

***Happiness delivery:** Born out of the tragic infant deaths in Kota in 2019, Suposhit Maa Abhiyan provides specially curated nutrition kits and regular medical check-ups to underweight expectant mothers and ensures their children get a healthy start in life*

By **ROHIT PARIHAR**

